

Inkest Business Plan

1. Executive Summary

Inkest is a private, Markdown-first workspace for personal notes, lightweight project management, diagrams, images, and AI-assisted thinking.

The product is designed for users who want the simplicity and ownership of Markdown, the polish of a modern SaaS app, and the privacy of a self-hostable system. Unlike heavy all-in-one workspaces, Inkest focuses on a calm writing experience, clean project organization, and explicit AI tools that help users think, summarize, plan, and structure their notes without taking control away from them.

The initial product will be launched as a self-hosted web application using Next.js, Turso/libSQL, and local filesystem storage. The first commercial opportunity is a hosted cloud version with sync, backup, AI credits, and premium themes.

2. Product Name

Name: Inkest

Domain: inkest.app

Tagline: A calm Markdown workspace for notes, projects, and private thinking.

3. Vision

Inkest should become the cleanest place for independent thinkers, developers, designers, founders, writers, and technical professionals to keep their notes, plan projects, document ideas, and use AI safely.

The long-term vision is not to become a Notion clone. Inkest should become a personal operating system for structured thinking: fast, private, elegant, Markdown-native, and exportable.

4. Mission

Inkest helps people turn scattered notes into clear thinking, organized projects, and reusable knowledge without sacrificing privacy, simplicity, or ownership.

5. Problem

Many people now use multiple tools for notes, tasks, documents, diagrams, and AI. This creates several problems:

1. Notes are scattered across different apps.
2. Project context gets separated from project tasks.
3. AI tools are useful but often disconnected from personal knowledge.
4. Many popular tools are too complex for personal use.
5. Users do not always control their data.
6. Markdown users often lack a beautiful web-based interface.

7. RTL and multilingual writing support is often treated as secondary.
8. Self-hosted tools are often powerful but visually weak.

The core problem: users want a private, beautiful, structured workspace that feels simple but can grow with their thinking.

6. Solution

Inkest solves this by combining:

- Markdown notes
- Beautiful editor and preview
- Mermaid diagrams
- Local image attachments
- Lightweight project management
- Tags, folders, and search
- Explicit AI actions
- English-first interface
- RTL-ready note writing
- Self-hosted deployment
- Clean export and backup

Inkest should feel like a writing studio, not a corporate workspace.

7. Target Customers

Primary Segment: Technical Knowledge Workers

These users include:

- Developers
- Software architects
- Product managers
- Designers
- Startup founders
- Independent consultants
- Researchers
- Technical writers

They value Markdown, structure, keyboard workflows, privacy, and long-term data ownership.

Secondary Segment: Indie Hackers and Self-Hosters

These users want:

- Self-hostable tools
- Docker deployment
- Local storage
- Simple databases
- Data export
- Control over AI provider keys

This group can become early adopters, testers, and promoters.

Tertiary Segment: Writers and Students

These users want:

- Clean notes
- Daily notes
- Task extraction
- Summaries
- Simple project organization
- PDF/image references later

This group may become important after the product has a hosted version.

8. Market Opportunity

The market is attractive because note-taking, personal knowledge management, and productivity software are already large categories. Users are familiar with tools like Notion, Obsidian, Standard Notes, Evernote, Anytype, Logseq, Bear, and Apple Notes.

However, the market still has space for a focused product because many existing tools force tradeoffs:

- Notion is polished but heavy and cloud-first.
- Obsidian is powerful and local-first but can feel plugin-heavy.
- Standard Notes is private but less project-oriented.
- Anytype is ambitious but can feel complex.
- Apple Notes is simple but not Markdown/project-native.
- Self-hosted tools often lack premium UI/UX.

Inkest should win by combining four qualities:

1. Beautiful UI/UX
2. Markdown-native data ownership
3. Self-hosted privacy
4. Useful AI actions

9. Positioning

Inkest should be positioned as:

A private Markdown workspace for notes, projects, diagrams, and AI-assisted thinking.

Shorter version:

Private notes. Clean projects. Markdown-native.

Positioning map:

- More beautiful than most self-hosted note tools.

- Simpler than Notion.
- More web-native than Obsidian.
- More project-oriented than Standard Notes.
- Less complex than Anytype.
- More private and exportable than typical AI note apps.

10. Unique Value Proposition

Inkest gives users a calm, private, beautiful place to write, organize, plan, and think in Markdown.

The key differentiators:

1. **Markdown-first** Notes remain portable and readable.
2. **UI/UX-first** The interface is not an afterthought. The product should feel premium from the first screen.
3. **Self-hosted MVP** Users can run it on their own server and keep images/files on their own filesystem.
4. **Project notes** Project management is built around notes, not a separate complicated system.
5. **Mermaid-native** Technical users can create flowcharts, diagrams, system designs, and plans directly inside notes.
6. **Explicit AI** AI is available when requested, not constantly running in the background.
7. **RTL-ready** English-first UI, but individual notes can support Persian, Arabic, Hebrew, and mixed-direction content.

11. Product Scope

MVP Features

- Authentication
- Dashboard
- Notes list
- Create/edit/delete/archive notes
- Markdown editor
- Markdown preview
- Mermaid diagram rendering
- Local image uploads
- Tags
- Folders or collections
- Search
- Project note type
- Task extraction from Markdown checkboxes
- RTL/LTR/auto direction per note
- Basic AI actions
- Settings page

- Markdown export

MVP AI Features

- Summarize note
- Improve writing
- Extract tasks
- Create project plan
- Generate Mermaid diagram
- Explain selected text
- Translate selected text

Post-MVP Features

- Hosted cloud version
- Sync and backup
- Note version history
- Daily notes
- Command palette
- Keyboard shortcuts
- Backlinks
- AI chat with selected notes
- Semantic search
- Mobile-friendly PWA
- Import Markdown folder
- Public sharing
- Team workspaces
- End-to-end encryption option

12. Business Model

Inkest should start with a self-hosted open-core or source-available model, then add a hosted commercial product.

Phase 1: Free Self-Hosted MVP

Purpose:

- Build trust
- Attract developers and self-hosters
- Collect feedback
- Prove the UX and product direction
- Create public credibility

Possible monetization in this phase:

- Paid early-access license
- Sponsorship
- Lifetime supporter license
- Paid setup service
- Consulting/custom deployment

Phase 2: Hosted Cloud SaaS

Suggested pricing:

Free

For evaluation and casual use.

Includes:

- Limited notes
- Limited storage
- Basic Markdown editor
- Basic AI trial credits
- Export

Pro — \$6 to \$10/month

For serious individual users.

Includes:

- Unlimited notes
- More storage
- Sync/backup
- AI actions
- Version history
- Advanced themes
- Priority export/import

Pro Plus — \$12 to \$18/month

For power users.

Includes:

- Higher AI limits
- Larger storage
- Advanced search
- Semantic search
- More backup retention
- Custom AI provider settings

Team — \$8 to \$15/user/month

For small teams later.

Includes:

- Shared workspaces
- Permissions

- Team project notes
- Admin controls
- Shared AI settings
- Audit/export tools

Optional Revenue Streams

- One-time self-hosted license
- Managed self-hosting
- Premium themes
- AI credit packs
- Private deployment for teams
- Custom plugin marketplace later
- Enterprise support later

13. Go-To-Market Strategy

Initial Audience

Start with technical users and indie hackers. They understand Markdown, privacy, self-hosting, and AI workflows.

Launch Channels

- Product Hunt
- Hacker News
- Reddit communities for self-hosting, PKM, Markdown, productivity, and Obsidian alternatives
- X/Twitter build-in-public posts
- GitHub repository
- Indie Hackers
- Dev.to articles
- YouTube demo videos
- Personal blog/SEO landing pages

Content Strategy

Write content around problems the audience already searches for:

- “Best self-hosted Markdown notes app”
- “Private Notion alternative”
- “Markdown project management app”
- “How to organize personal projects in Markdown”
- “Self-hosted AI notes app”
- “Mermaid diagrams in Markdown notes”
- “Obsidian vs Notion vs self-hosted notes”
- “Personal knowledge management for developers”

Launch Plan

Pre-launch

- Build landing page at inkest.app

- Collect waitlist emails
- Publish product screenshots
- Share development progress
- Publish technical architecture article
- Invite 20–50 early testers

MVP Launch

- Release self-hosted Docker version
- Publish GitHub repo or source-available package
- Publish demo video
- Launch on Product Hunt and Hacker News
- Ask early users for workflow feedback

Post-launch

- Add hosted beta
- Convert engaged self-hosted users to paid cloud users
- Add AI features based on usage
- Publish comparison pages
- Build community around Markdown/private productivity

14. Sales Strategy

Inkest should not start with enterprise sales. The first motion should be product-led growth.

Individual User Sales

Users discover Inkest through content, demos, GitHub, and community posts. They try the self-hosted version or hosted free version. They upgrade for convenience, sync, backups, AI, and polish.

Team Sales Later

Small teams may want a private workspace for internal notes, project planning, and AI-assisted documentation. The team product should come only after the personal product is strong.

Self-Hosted Commercial Sales

Some users and small businesses may want private deployment but do not want to manage it themselves. Offer:

- Installation service
- Managed VPS deployment
- Support subscription
- Custom branding
- Backup setup

15. Competitive Landscape

Notion

Strengths:

- Very polished
- Broad feature set
- Databases and collaboration
- Strong templates and ecosystem
- AI built in

Weaknesses Inkest can exploit:

- Heavy for personal Markdown users
- Cloud-first
- Not Markdown-native
- Less appealing to self-hosters

Obsidian

Strengths:

- Markdown-native
- Local-first
- Strong plugin ecosystem
- Excellent for personal knowledge management

Weaknesses Inkest can exploit:

- Desktop-first mental model
- Plugins can become complex
- Web/self-hosted experience is not the main product
- UI can feel less SaaS-polished depending on setup

Standard Notes

Strengths:

- Strong privacy positioning
- Encryption
- Simple note-taking
- Cross-platform

Weaknesses Inkest can exploit:

- Less focused on project management
- Less visual/diagram-oriented
- Less developer/project workflow focus

Anytype

Strengths:

- Local-first
- Privacy-focused
- Powerful object model
- Broad workspace concept

Weaknesses Inkest can exploit:

- Can feel complex
- Heavier mental model
- Markdown-first users may prefer a simpler tool

Inkest Differentiation

Inkest should stay focused:

- Beautiful Markdown workspace
- Personal notes plus lightweight projects
- Self-hosted first
- Local file storage
- Explicit AI tools
- Diagrams and technical thinking support
- Clean export and ownership

16. Product Roadmap

Month 1-2: Prototype

Build:

- Landing page
- Auth
- Notes CRUD
- Markdown editor
- Preview
- Basic layout
- Local database
- Local filesystem uploads

Goal:

- Prove the core writing experience.

Month 3: MVP

Build:

- Mermaid support
- Tags

- Search
- Project note type
- Basic tasks
- Basic AI summarize/improve/extract
- Docker deployment

Goal:

- Have a usable self-hosted product.

Month 4–5: Private Beta

Build:

- Better UI polish
- Export
- Settings
- Version history
- More AI actions
- Onboarding flow
- Documentation

Goal:

- Test with 20–50 real users.

Month 6: Public Launch

Build:

- Website
- Demo video
- Public docs
- Install guide
- Feedback system
- Early supporter plan

Goal:

- Launch publicly and collect first paying supporters.

Month 7–9: Hosted Beta

Build:

- Cloud hosting
- User billing
- Cloud storage
- Backup
- AI credits
- Better search

Goal:

- Convert users from free/self-hosted to paid hosted plans.

Month 10–12: Growth

Build:

- Import/export improvements
- Semantic search
- Daily notes
- Command palette
- PWA improvements
- Comparison pages
- Team workspace research

Goal:

- Reach predictable monthly recurring revenue.

17. Technology Plan

MVP Stack

- Next.js App Router
- TypeScript
- Tailwind CSS
- shadcn/ui
- Drizzle ORM
- Turso/libSQL
- CodeMirror 6
- React Markdown
- Mermaid
- Auth.js
- Local filesystem storage
- OpenAI-compatible AI provider

Why This Stack

This stack keeps the product simple, modern, and self-hostable. It also supports future migration to a hosted SaaS model without rewriting the entire system.

Technical Principles

- Keep notes as Markdown text.
- Keep file storage separate from the database.
- Keep AI provider abstraction flexible.
- Keep all note access scoped by user.
- Keep export/import as a first-class feature.
- Keep the UI component system clean and reusable.

18. Operations Plan

Initial Team

The MVP can be built by one strong full-stack developer.

Required roles over time:

- Founder/full-stack engineer
- Product/UI designer
- Part-time content marketer
- Part-time support/community manager
- Security reviewer later

Infrastructure

MVP:

- Self-hosted Docker deployment
- Local filesystem storage
- Turso/libSQL or local SQLite/libSQL
- Optional reverse proxy

Hosted SaaS later:

- Managed application hosting
- Managed database
- Object storage
- Email service
- Billing provider
- Monitoring
- Error tracking
- Backups

Support

Start with:

- GitHub issues
- Email support
- Docs
- Discord or private community later

19. Pricing Strategy

Recommended early pricing:

Self-hosted Community

Free for personal use, with optional supporter license.

Self-hosted Pro License

\$49–\$99 one-time early supporter license.

Includes:

- Premium themes
- Early AI features
- Priority updates
- Supporter badge
- Future discount for cloud plan

Hosted Pro

\$8/month or \$80/year.

Includes:

- Hosted app
- Backups
- Sync
- AI credits
- Version history
- More storage

Hosted Power

\$15/month or \$150/year.

Includes:

- More AI usage
- Semantic search
- More storage
- Longer backup retention
- Advanced export

Pricing should stay simple. The first goal is not maximum ARPU; it is adoption and product-market learning.

20. Key Metrics

Product Metrics

- Weekly active users
- Notes created per user
- Notes edited per user
- Number of returning users after 7 days
- Number of returning users after 30 days
- AI actions used per user
- Images uploaded

- Projects created
- Exports generated

Business Metrics

- Waitlist conversion rate
- Free-to-paid conversion rate
- Monthly recurring revenue
- Churn
- Customer acquisition cost
- Lifetime value
- Support requests per active user

UX Metrics

- Time to first note
- Time to first successful AI action
- Time to first project note
- Editor save reliability
- User-reported writing experience score

21. Financial Model

Assumptions

The first year should be treated as a validation year, not an aggressive revenue year.

Example conservative target:

- 1,000 waitlist users
- 300 active MVP users
- 100 hosted beta users
- 50 paid users
- Average revenue per paid user: \$8/month

This creates:

- Monthly recurring revenue: \$400
- Annualized recurring revenue: \$4,800

Example stronger target:

- 5,000 waitlist users
- 1,500 active MVP users
- 500 hosted beta users
- 200 paid users
- Average revenue per paid user: \$10/month

This creates:

- Monthly recurring revenue: \$2,000
- Annualized recurring revenue: \$24,000

The early goal should be signal, retention, and product love. Revenue becomes more meaningful after the hosted version, sync, backup, and AI features are stable.

22. Main Risks

Risk 1: Crowded Market

There are many note-taking apps.

Mitigation:

- Narrow positioning.
- Focus on Markdown, privacy, self-hosting, and UI quality.
- Do not compete directly with Notion on breadth.

Risk 2: Too Many Features

The product can become complex quickly.

Mitigation:

- Keep Markdown as the core.
- Keep project management lightweight.
- Avoid collaboration until later.
- Avoid plugin systems in MVP.

Risk 3: AI Privacy Concerns

Users may not want private notes sent to AI providers.

Mitigation:

- Make AI explicit.
- Show what will be sent.
- Support custom AI keys.
- Support local/self-hosted model providers later.
- Store AI logs transparently.

Risk 4: Self-Hosted Users May Not Pay

Self-hosters often prefer free tools.

Mitigation:

- Monetize convenience, hosted sync, backup, AI, and support.
- Offer early supporter licenses.
- Offer managed deployment.

Risk 5: UX Quality Takes Time

UI/UX is a core differentiator and cannot be rushed.

Mitigation:

- Build fewer features with higher polish.
- Treat onboarding, empty states, editor feel, and preview quality as core product work.
- Use a design system early.

23. Legal and Compliance Considerations

Inkest should consider:

- Trademark search for “Inkest”
- Privacy policy
- Terms of service
- AI usage disclosure
- Data export rights
- Cookie policy if needed
- GDPR-ready deletion/export workflows for hosted version
- Clear self-hosted license terms

For the hosted version, users must understand whether their notes are encrypted, whether AI providers receive selected content, and how backups are stored.

24. Brand Strategy

Brand Personality

- Calm
- Private
- Elegant
- Precise
- Thoughtful
- Minimal
- Developer-friendly

Visual Direction

- Warm paper-like backgrounds
- Dark ink typography
- Subtle borders
- Premium spacing
- Minimal icons
- Soft accent color
- Excellent dark mode

Voice

Inkest should sound clear, calm, and practical.

Avoid:

- Hype

- Corporate jargon
- “AI will replace your thinking”
- Overpromising privacy before technical proof

Use:

- “Private by design”
- “Markdown-native”
- “Own your notes”
- “Think clearly”
- “Projects without clutter”

25. 12-Month Execution Plan

Quarter 1

- Build prototype
- Validate UI direction
- Implement core notes
- Build landing page
- Start waitlist
- Share build-in-public content

Quarter 2

- Launch self-hosted MVP
- Add Markdown preview, Mermaid, image upload, tags, search
- Add basic AI actions
- Invite early users
- Collect feedback
- Improve onboarding

Quarter 3

- Launch public beta
- Add export, backups, version history
- Start supporter pricing
- Publish comparison content
- Improve docs
- Prepare hosted SaaS

Quarter 4

- Launch hosted beta
- Add billing
- Add sync/backup/storage limits
- Add AI credit model
- Improve retention
- Explore team workspace demand

26. First 90-Day Action Plan

Days 1–15

- Finalize name and positioning
- Buy domain
- Create landing page
- Create product design system
- Create technical architecture
- Build app shell

Days 16–30

- Implement auth
- Implement database schema
- Implement notes CRUD
- Implement editor layout
- Implement Markdown editor

Days 31–45

- Add preview
- Add Mermaid
- Add image upload
- Add tags
- Add search
- Add note direction

Days 46–60

- Add project note type
- Add tasks
- Add dashboard
- Add settings
- Add export

Days 61–75

- Add AI actions
- Add Docker deployment
- Add docs
- Add onboarding
- Invite early testers

Days 76–90

- Fix UX issues
- Improve performance
- Polish UI
- Publish demo
- Launch self-hosted MVP
- Collect first payments or supporter licenses

27. Final Recommendation

Inkest is a viable product idea if it stays focused.

The winning version is not “another note app.” The winning version is:

A beautiful, private, Markdown-native workspace for people who think, plan, and build.

The first product should be small, polished, self-hostable, and highly usable. The business should start with community trust and then monetize convenience: hosted sync, backups, AI, storage, and support.